Country Profile: Finland

Nation-Building Policies Dataset

- Number of groups in country: 4
- Plurality religion: Lutheranism
- Official language: Finnish and Swedish
- Official religion: None
- Core group: Finns

Historical Background

Finland is a presidential republic. In 1917, Finland declared independence from the Russian Empire. A major territorial loss occurred after World War II, under the 1944 interim peace treaty with the Soviet Union, wherein Finland ceded parts of Karelia and other areas.[1] Since then, Finland's borders have remained stable.

Groups

- **Finns**, comprising 93% of the population, constitute the core ethnic group in the country. They speak Finnish,[2] which also serves as one of the two state languages. Language and religion are the key markers of the Finnish identity.[3] The majority is affiliated with Lutheranism. A smaller but growing portion identifies with no religious belief.[4]
- **Sámi** are a nested and the officially recognized Indigenous group of Finland, comprising less than 0.5% of the national population.[5] The main linguistic subgroups include **Northern Sami**, **Inari Sami**, and **Skolt Sami**. The Sámi Homeland is legally defined and covers the northern municipalities of Enontekiö, Inari, Utsjoki, and parts of the Lappi reindeer herding district in Sodankylä.[6] All

[1] Armistice Agreement between Finland and the USSR and the UK, 1944.
[2] Official Statistics of Finland, 2021.
[3] From and Sahlström, 2017.
[4] EPR-ED, 2021.
[5] Official Statistics of Finland, 2021.
[6] Act on the Sámi Parliament, 1995.

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three main Sami languages are classified as endangered,[7] as the Sámi predominantly use Finnish. Historically, the Sámi practiced animist and shamanic traditions but were largely Christianized by the 19th century.[8] Today, most Northern and Inari Sámi are affiliated with Lutheranism, while the Skolt Sámi are primarily Eastern Orthodox.[9] Sámi activists have pursued cultural and territorial autonomy since 1973, when they established the Nordic Sámi Institute and began electing a Sámi Parliament in Finland.[10]

- **Finland Swedes** comprise approximately 5% of Finland's population; their share has decreased by almost half compared to the 1940s.[11] They are concentrated mostly in the coastal regions of **Österbotten, Nyland, and Åboland**, as well as on the **Åland Islands**—areas inhabited by Swedish-speakers since **before the 12th century**.[12] The group speaks **Swedish**, which is recognized as one of Finland's two **official languages**. Religiously, the majority follows **Lutheranism,** with **the remaining one-fourth identifying as non-religious**.[13] Finland Swedes have not engaged in self-determination movements on the mainland, but the **Åland Islands**, which have autonomous status, have experienced a **revival of separatist nationalism** since 1990. Political parties on Åland have since campaigned for greater autonomy and, at times, **full independence within the European Union**.[14]
- **Russian Speakers** make up around 2% of the national population.[15] The vast majority arrived since the collapse of the Soviet Union in 1991.[16] While most Russian speakers can speak Finnish, Russian remains central to their group identity. Religiously, two-thirds of the group adhere to the Russian Orthodox church, while the remainder largely identify as non-religious.[17]

[7] Ethnologue, 2024.
[8] Viimaranta et al., 2018.
[9] EPR-ED, 2021.
[10] Sambanis et al., 2018.
[11] Official Statistics of Finland, 2021.
[12] Minority Rights, 2015.
[13] EPR-ED, 2021.
[14] Sambanis, Germann, and Schädel, 2018.
[15] Official Statistics of Finland, 2021.
[16] Viimaranta et al., 2018.
[17] EPR-ED, 2021.

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State Profile

Official Language

Finland has two official national languages: Finnish and Swedish. This status is codified in Section 17 of the 1999 Constitution, which designates both languages as statutory national working languages.[18] Finnish is the majority language and the primary medium of communication, while Swedish holds equal legal status, including the right to access public services, education, and government communication in Swedish.[19] The Sámi languages—Northern Sámi, Inari Sámi, and Skolt Sámi—are recognized under the 2003 Sámi Language Act (No. 1086) as statutory languages of provincial identity in the municipalities of Enontekiö, Inari, Sodankylä, and Utsjoki, all located in the Lapland region.[20]

Official Religion

Finland does not have an official state religion. The Evangelical Lutheran Church is specifically recognized in Article 76: "Provisions on the organization and administration of the Evangelic Lutheran Church are laid down in the Church Act."

Education Policies

Compulsory education in Finland begins with pre-primary education, which became mandatory in 2015 for all 6-year-olds. This is followed by comprehensive basic education covering grades 1–9, starting at age 7. After completing basic education, students are legally required to continue in upper secondary education until age 18, a reform introduced in 2021.[21]

The vast majority of students attend municipal schools, although there are also state and private schools. Private schools operate under a public funding model, and many follow the national curriculum, making them effectively part of the public system. Instruction is non-segregated, and no tuition fees are charged by either public or private schools that receive public subsidies.[22]

[18] Constitution of Finland, 1999.
[19] Constitution of Finland, 1999.
[20] Act on the Sámi Language, 2003.
[21] Eurydice, 2024.
[22] Eurydice, 2024.

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Language Education Policies

Language education in Finland is closely tied to its official bilingual framework and regional minority protections. **Finnish** is the majority language and the standard language of instruction across the country at both primary and secondary levels. **Swedish**, the country's second national language, is taught as a compulsory language class to all pupils in public schools starting at the primary level, a policy in place since 1977.[23] Before this reform, Swedish had been mandatory only at the secondary level for Finnish-speaking students. In municipalities with established Swedish-speaking populations, Swedish is also used as a language of instruction during the study period.[24]

Sámi languages—**Northern Sámi**, **Inari Sámi**, **and Skolt Sámi**—are protected as languages of instruction within the Sámi Homeland.[25] Sámi-language education began formally in the 1975–76 school year for primary school, with statutory recognition granted by the 1985 education law and reinforced under the 1998 Basic Education Act, extending the instruction in Sami languages to secondary schools within the Sami Homeland.[26] Sámi languages are not taught as language classes across Finland; the main focus is on Sámi as a language of instruction in regions of their compact residence.[27]

A private Russian-Finnish school was established in Helsinki in 1955, which offered early childhood education as well as primary and secondary schooling. This institution became state supported during the 1977 comprehensive school reform and was renamed the Finnish-Russian School.[28] At that stage, **Russian** was taught as a school subject at the primary school level. In 1998, in response to growing immigration from the former Soviet Union, Russian was introduced as a language of instruction in bilingual programs at both primary and secondary levels, particularly in Helsinki. [29]

Religious Education Policies

Religious education in Finnish schools is part of the national curriculum, and instruction is organized according to the pupil's religious affiliation.[30] This model has its roots in the

[23] Latomaa and Nuolijärvi, 2002.
[24] Björklund et al., 2017.
[25] Aikio-Puoskari, 2009.
[26] Latomaa and Nuolijärvi, 2002; Aikio-Puoskari, 2009.
[27] Aikio-Puoskari, 2009.
[28] Potrassova, 2008, 130.
[29] Potrassova, 2008, 130.
[30] EARS, 2021; Sakaranaho, 2013.

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1923 Primary School Act, which guaranteed instruction both in the religion of the majority and, upon request, for minority religious groups. That same law also mandated the provision of ethics education for pupils with no religious affiliation.[31] Under the 1998 Basic Education Act, the system was reaffirmed and codified in greater detail. Schools are required to provide religious education that corresponds to the religion of the majority of pupils. In most cases, this means Evangelical Lutheran religious education. However, pupils who are not members of this community may also attend Lutheran instruction if their guardians request it.[32]

In addition, if at least three pupils in a municipality belong to the Orthodox Church and do not attend Lutheran religious education, the municipality is obligated to organize Orthodox religious education for them. The law allows similar arrangements for other recognized religious communities, provided there is sufficient demand.[33] Pupils who do not belong to any religious group are assigned to ethics education.[34]

Constitutions and Laws

Finland's first modern independent constitution was adopted in 1919, following the country's independence from Russia. This established parliamentary democracy and key linguistic and religious rights. Article 14 states "Finnish and Swedish shall be the national languages of the Republic." The same article contains explicit references to both Finns and Swedes, stating that "care shall be taken to ensure that the rights of the Finnish population and the rights of the Swedish population are protected according to the same principles. The state shall meet the intellectual and economic needs of both the Finnish and Swedish populations on an equal basis."[35] Freedom of religion was also protected, Article 8 states "Every Finnish citizen shall have the right to worship in public and in private." Article 9 states "Profession of religion or the fact of belonging to no religion shall have no influence upon the rights and duties of Finnish citizens."[36]

A major constitutional reform in 1995 significantly expanded Finland's framework for linguistic and cultural rights through the introduction of Section 17. This provision

[31] Sakaranaho, 2013; Alberts, 2007.
[32] Sakaranaho, 2013; Basic Education Act, 1998. 13:1.
[33] Sakaranaho, 2013.
[34] Laki kansakoulun järjestysmuodon perusteista, 1923.
[35] Constitution of Finland, 1919.
[36] Constitution of Finland, 1919.

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reaffirmed the national language status of both Finnish and Swedish and explicitly recognized the Sámi, Roma, and other groups' rights to maintain and develop their own languages and cultures. The Constitution clearly named Finns, Swedes, and Sámi as groups whose rights warranted specific protection: public authorities were obligated to ensure the educational, cultural, and societal needs of both Finnish- and Swedish-speaking populations were met on an equal basis (Section 17.1–2).[37]

A new Constitution was adopted in 1999 and came into force on March 1, 2000. This version retained all key rights from the 1995 reform, including Section 17 on language and cultural rights, explicitly mentioning Finns, Sami, and Swedes. Religious provisions remained largely unaltered, confirming the universal recognition of religious freedom and special mention of Lutheran Church in the Constitution.[38]

Citizenship Laws

Finland's citizenship policy is grounded in the principle of *jus sanguinis*. According to Section 9(1) of the Finnish Nationality Act (2003), a child automatically acquires Finnish citizenship at birth if either parent is a Finnish citizen, regardless of the place of birth. A child born in Finland may acquire Finnish citizenship by birth if the parents have been granted refugee status or other protection from the authorities of their country of nationality. This applies only if the child does not automatically acquire either parent's citizenship at birth, unless doing so would require registration or other procedures involving the authorities of the parent's home country. If only one parent has been granted protection, the child must not acquire the other parent's citizenship at birth or even have a secondary right to it through birth.[39] Foreign nationals may acquire Finnish citizenship through naturalization, regulated by Section 13 of the Act. Sections 31–33 provide for simplified naturalization for Nordic citizens (Sweden, Norway, Denmark, and Iceland), who may acquire Finnish citizenship by declaration after two years of residence, without fulfilling the full naturalization criteria such as language testing or income documentation.[40]

[37] Constitution Act of Finland, 1995.
[38] Constitution of Finland, 1999.
[39] Finnish Nationality Act, 2003.
[40] Finnish Nationality Act, 2003.

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National Anthem(s)

Finland's national anthem, "Maamme" [Our Land], was adopted in 1917, following independence from the Russian Empire, though it had long served as a *de facto* anthem since the mid-19th century. The anthem reflects themes of natural beauty, love for the homeland, and moral virtue, rather than military triumph or ethnic nationalism. It opens with the lines: "Our land, our land, our fatherland, Sound loud, O name of worth!" expressing reverence for the nation.[41] "Maamme" does not mention ethnicity or bloodline, instead focusing on a shared civic and geographic identity. It highlights the landscape and reinforces patriotism through peaceful imagery and poetic expression. While unofficial discussions have occasionally questioned its formal status—since it has never been established by law—"Maamme" continues to be the widely accepted and performed national anthem of Finland, symbolizing a non-ethnic conception of nationhood.

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